



EXPLORING ENTERPRISE SYSTEMS WITH PPG: From SAP Implementation to Career Opportunities

Year 3 Data Engineering students from Universiti Teknologi Malaysia (UTM) recently had the opportunity to attend an insightful industry talk delivered by Mr. Patrick from PPG Industries, a global leader in paints, coatings, and specialty materials.

During the session, Mr. Patrick provided an in-depth overview of how PPG leverages Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) systems, particularly SAP to streamline its global operations across departments. He also discussed the company's transition to SAP S/4HANA, a next-generation system designed to enhance efficiency, integration, and data-driven decision-making within large-scale enterprises. In addition to the technical insights, Mr. Patrick introduced various career opportunities available at PPG and emphasizing the importance of practical experience and digital skills in today's competitive job market. The talk was both informative and inspiring, offering UTM students a valuable glimpse into how data engineering and enterprise systems play a vital role in driving global digital transformation.

TECHNOLOGY AND ISSUES DISCUSSED

The speakers elaborated on the SAP ecosystem that PPG uses to support its enterprise operations. They discussed how SAP modules such as Finance and Controlling (FI/CO), Materials Management (MM), and Sales and Distribution (SD) work together to connect different business functions under one unified system. For example, data from procurement in the MM module automatically updates financial records in FI/CO, allowing real-time visibility and better decision-making. They also spoke about SAP S/4HANA, the next-generation ERP platform that PPG is gradually adopting to enhance performance and analytics. Unlike traditional systems, SAP S/4HANA processes data in real time, which helps PPG improve supply chain planning, optimize production schedules, and respond faster to customer demands.

One of the main challenges highlighted was data integration. Since PPG operates in many countries, ensuring consistency and standardization across multiple plants and departments can be difficult. Mr. Patrick emphasized the need for strong data governance and global templates to maintain accuracy across different systems. The speakers also touched on the importance of user training and change management, reminding us digital transformation succeeds only when people adapt with technology.

INDIVIDUAL REFLECTION

Lim Yu Han

This talk really opened my eyes to how enterprise systems operate in real businesses. I've learned that SAP is not just an accounting or data tool, it's a complete ecosystem that connects every part of an organization. Seeing how PPG manages such a complex network through SAP inspired me to think about how technology can simplify operations and support smarter decision-making. What stood out to me was the balance between technology and people. Both speakers shared that while systems like SAP S/4HANA are powerful, the success of digital transformation depends on collaboration and communication between teams. As a student studying enterprise system design, I found this talk very motivating, it encouraged me to explore more about ERP implementation, business process integration, and digital innovation as part of my future career path.

Poh Lok Yee

Mr. Patrick Thong from PPG Industries really sparked my curiosity about SAP. I loved learning how ERP systems connect different parts of a business and make real-time decision-making possible. I also realized that technology alone isn't enough—data governance and user training are just as important. After this session, I feel excited to dive deeper into SAP and see how I can use it in my future career.